

D569

Adult Psychology

Armored Drill

8 concepts · 12 items · 4 transfer items

What this is. Every concept in this course's public description, re-asked with more disguise than a practice test uses. Each stem carries facts that do not decide it. Every wrong answer is a named trap.

Source. Scope from the course's public description in the WGU Institutional Catalog (September 2026); items written from the field's standard body of knowledge. No WGU assessment item, course material or proprietary content is used or reproduced. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Western Governors University.

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How to run it

Paper first. Pencil. One pass, no notes, a timer if you want the pressure.

1. **Before you read the options**, fill the strip under the item: the target word (what is actually being asked), and the one fact in the stem that decides it.
2. **Principle before arithmetic**. Name the rule, then compute.
3. **Camouflage**. Most of every stem does not matter. Ask: which single fact decides this?
4. **Inverse pairs are the bait**. If two options are opposites, one of them is the trap built for you.
5. **Mark sure, unsure or guess** honestly. Sure-and-wrong is the most valuable miss on the page — it is a wrong mental model.
6. **Absolutes** (always, never, guarantee) are usually wrong. And recognizing an answer is not the same as owning it.
7. Items with a **heavy black bar** on the left are **transfer items**: the same principle, reversed or solved for a different variable.
8. Stop at the STOP page. Then grade, fill the triage grid, and tally the traps you fell for. The biggest tally is what you drill next.

The strip, filled in, looks like this:

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	_____	

Items

1.

A 52-year-old engineer who drives a vintage convertible starts mentoring young employees and coaching a youth robotics team, saying he wants to “leave something behind.” His wife is an avid gardener. Which psychosocial task is he working on?

- A. Generativity vs. stagnation.
- B. Intimacy vs. isolation.
- C. Identity vs. role confusion, since mentoring is about finding oneself.
- D. Integrity vs. despair.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

2. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

An 81-year-old reviews her life and says she regrets many choices and feels it is too late to change anything. Which outcome of which stage does this reflect?

- A. Stagnation, the negative outcome of generativity vs. stagnation.
- B. Despair, the negative outcome of integrity vs. despair.
- C. Integrity, the positive outcome of integrity vs. despair.
- D. Isolation, because all older adults become isolated.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

3.

A 68-year-old retired judge who lives near a lake takes two tests. She is slower than young adults at a timed puzzle with unfamiliar shapes but scores higher than them on vocabulary and legal reasoning. She walks two miles each morning. Which pattern does this illustrate?

- A. Her daily walks protected her fluid intelligence.
- B. Declining fluid intelligence with stable or rising crystallized intelligence.
- C. Declining crystallized intelligence with stable fluid intelligence.
- D. Overall decline, since all intelligence falls after 60.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

4. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Which task would most likely show the largest age-related decline across adulthood?

- A.** Answering questions about one's long-time profession.
- B.** Recalling general world knowledge.
- C.** Quickly solving unfamiliar pattern puzzles under a time limit.
- D.** Defining difficult vocabulary words.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

5.

A 77-year-old man who once managed a busy hardware store now declines most invitations to large gatherings and spends his time with his wife, two old friends, and his grandchildren. He reports being very content. He recently bought a new recliner. Which theory best explains his choice?

- A.** Activity theory.
- B.** Disengagement theory, meaning he is withdrawing from society.
- C.** Socioemotional selectivity theory.
- D.** Depression, since smaller networks always signal loneliness.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

6.

An 80-year-old concert pianist who lives in a high-rise apartment keeps performing by playing fewer pieces, practicing them more, and slowing down before fast passages so the fast parts sound quicker by contrast. Her building has a doorman. Which model does this illustrate?

- A.** Decline, because using strategies shows she can no longer play well.
- B.** Socioemotional selectivity theory.
- C.** Disengagement theory.
- D.** Selective optimization with compensation.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

7.

A 22-year-old who grew up in a suburban town has changed majors twice, moved three times in two years, and says, "I don't feel like a teenager, but I don't feel fully adult either." He works part-time at a bike shop. Which developmental concept best fits?

- A. A universal biological stage all 22-year-olds go through.
- B. A midlife crisis.
- C. Arrested development, since true adults never feel in-between.
- D. Emerging adulthood.

Target word _____	The one fact that decides _____	Answer ____	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
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8.

A research team at a university with a new medical campus tests memory in 1,000 adults aged 20, 40, 60, and 80, all in the same month. The 80-year-olds score lowest. The study was featured in a news segment. What is the main limitation in concluding that memory declines as a person ages?

- A. The sample of 1,000 is too small to find any age effect.
- B. There is no limitation, since cross-sectional studies directly show individual change.
- C. Attrition, because participants dropped out over the years.
- D. Cohort effects: the age groups grew up with different education and experiences.

Target word _____	The one fact that decides _____	Answer ____	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
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9. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A study follows the same 500 adults, testing them every five years from age 40 to 80. What is its main strength and a key weakness?

- A. It shows change within individuals, but it risks attrition and practice effects.
- B. It removes cohort effects entirely and has no weaknesses.
- C. It is fast and inexpensive to run.
- D. It compares different age groups at one time, risking cohort effects.

Target word _____	The one fact that decides _____	Answer ____	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
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10.

A retired high-school history teacher who lives in a small river town now leads walking tours of local historic sites and writes a column on town history. He has two adult children. He says staying with the subject he has always loved keeps him feeling like himself. Which theory best explains his adjustment?

- A.** Socioemotional selectivity theory.
- B.** Disengagement theory.
- C.** Continuity theory.
- D.** Activity theory.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

11.

A woman who grew up on a dairy farm entered the workforce during a major national recession, and many people her age had delayed careers and home buying. She later became a nurse. Which type of influence is the recession?

- A.** Not a developmental influence, since economics do not shape development.
- B.** Normative history-graded.
- C.** Normative age-graded.
- D.** Non-normative.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

12. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Which example is a non-normative influence on development?

- A.** Surviving a rare disease at age 30.
- B.** Starting school around age 5.
- C.** Growing up during a global pandemic.
- D.** Going through menopause around age 50.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

STOP

Answers and dissection follow. Finish every item and every strip first.

Key and dissection

Struck-through text is the camouflage: facts that do not decide the item.

1. Answer A Concept 1

A 52-year-old engineer ~~who drives a vintage convertible~~ starts mentoring young employees and coaching a youth robotics team, saying he wants to “leave something behind.” ~~His wife is an avid gardener.~~ Which psychosocial task is he working on?

Target word: psychosocial stage **Decides:** Midlife concern with guiding the next generation.

A	Correct	Mentoring and leaving a legacy define generativity.
B	Confusion set	Intimacy centers on forming close partnerships in young adulthood.
C	Inverted operation	That is an adolescent task; he is investing in others, not defining himself.
D	Adjacent category	Integrity is late-life review and acceptance of one’s life.

2. Answer B Concept 1 • transfer

An 81-year-old reviews her life and says she regrets many choices and feels it is too late to change anything. Which outcome of which stage does this reflect?

Target word: stage and pole from a statement — reverse direction **Decides:** Late-life review ending in regret.

A	Adjacent category	Stagnation is midlife self-absorption, not late-life regret.
B	Correct	Bitterness and regret at life review is despair.
C	Inverted operation	Integrity is acceptance and peace with one’s life.
D	Absolute language	Isolation belongs to young adulthood, and it is not universal.

3. Answer B Concept 2

A 68-year-old retired judge ~~who lives near a lake~~ takes two tests. She is slower than young adults at a timed puzzle with unfamiliar shapes but scores higher than them on vocabulary and legal reasoning. ~~She walks two miles each morning.~~ Which pattern does this illustrate?

Target word: which intelligence changes which way **Decides:** Novel timed task vs. accumulated knowledge.

A	Camouflage	Her fluid score is lower; the walks do not explain the pattern.
B	Correct	Speed on new problems falls; knowledge and expertise hold or grow.
C	Inverted operation	Reverses the two.
D	Absolute language	Her vocabulary and reasoning scores are higher than young adults’.

4. Answer C Concept 2 • transfer

Which task would most likely show the largest age-related decline across adulthood?

Target word: task tapping fluid intelligence **Decides:** Speed and novelty.

A	Inverted operation	Expertise grows or holds with age.
B	Adjacent category	Semantic knowledge is largely preserved.
C	Correct	Taps processing speed and novel reasoning—fluid abilities.
D	Confusion set	A crystallized skill that holds up with age.

5. Answer C Concept 3

A 77-year-old man ~~who once managed a busy hardware store~~ now declines most invitations to large gatherings and spends his time with his wife, two old friends, and his grandchildren. He reports being very content. ~~He recently bought a new recliner.~~ Which theory best explains his choice?

Target word: explain a smaller, closer network **Decides:** Limited time horizon leads to prioritizing emotional meaning.

A	Inverted operation	Activity theory would predict well-being from more activities and roles.
B	Confusion set	He is not withdrawing from everyone; he is selecting meaningful ties and is content.
C	Correct	He focuses on emotionally close relationships as time feels more limited.
D	Absolute language	He reports contentment; smaller networks can be a positive choice.

6. Answer D Concept 4

An 80-year-old concert pianist ~~who lives in a high-rise apartment~~ keeps performing by playing fewer pieces, practicing them more, and slowing down before fast passages so the fast parts sound quicker by contrast. ~~Her building has a doorman.~~ Which model does this illustrate?

Target word: aging adaptation model **Decides:** Select, optimize, and compensate.

A	Dropped element	Drops the point that compensation is a sign of successful adaptation.
B	Confusion set	That theory concerns relationships and emotional goals, not skill strategies.
C	Inverted operation	She is continuing to perform, not withdrawing.
D	Correct	Fewer pieces (selection), more practice (optimization), tempo contrast (compensation).

7. Answer D Concept 5

A 22-year-old ~~who grew up in a suburban town~~ has changed majors twice, moved three times in two years, and says, "I don't feel like a teenager, but I don't feel fully adult either." ~~He works part time at a bike shop.~~ Which developmental concept best fits?

Target word: life-stage concept **Decides:** Exploration, instability, and feeling in-between at about 18–25.

A	Confusion set	Emerging adulthood is shaped by culture and economic context, not universal.
B	Adjacent category	Midlife reappraisal occurs decades later.
C	Absolute language	Feeling in-between is typical of this period in industrialized societies.
D	Correct	Identity exploration, instability, and feeling in-between define this period.

8. Answer D Concept 6

A research team at a university ~~with a new medical campus~~ tests memory in 1,000 adults aged 20, 40, 60, and 80, all in the same month. The 80-year-olds score lowest. ~~The study was featured in a news segment.~~ What is the main limitation in concluding that memory declines as a person ages?

Target word: limitation of the design **Decides:** Different age groups measured once—cross-sectional.

A	Wrong stem number	Sample size is not the key limitation here.
B	Inverted operation	They compare different people, not change within people.
C	Confusion set	Attrition is a longitudinal problem; everyone was tested once.
D	Correct	Cross-sectional differences may reflect generation, not aging.

9. Answer A Concept 6 • transfer

A study follows the same 500 adults, testing them every five years from age 40 to 80. What is its main strength and a key weakness?

Target word: longitudinal strengths and limits **Decides:** Same people over time.

A	Correct	Following the same people reveals true change but loses participants and invites test familiarity.
B	Absolute language	A single cohort still limits generalization, and attrition remains.
C	Inverted operation	Longitudinal studies are slow and costly.
D	Confusion set	That describes cross-sectional design.

10. Answer C Concept 7

A retired high-school history teacher ~~who lives in a small river town~~ now leads walking tours of local historic sites and writes a column on town history. ~~He has two adult children.~~ He says staying with the subject he has always loved keeps him feeling like himself. Which theory best explains his adjustment?

Target word: aging theory **Decides:** Maintaining long-standing interests and identity in a new form.

A	Adjacent category	That theory focuses on narrowing relationships, not on continuing an interest.
B	Inverted operation	He is engaging, not withdrawing.
C	Correct	He adapts by keeping familiar patterns and identity.
D	Confusion set	Activity theory stresses staying busy with any roles; the key here is continuity of lifelong interest.

11. Answer B Concept 8

A woman ~~who grew up on a dairy farm~~ entered the workforce during a major national recession, and many people her age had delayed careers and home buying. ~~She later became a nurse.~~ Which type of influence is the recession?

Target word: life-course influence type **Decides:** An event that affects a whole generation at once.

A	Absolute language	Economic events clearly shape life paths.
B	Correct	A widely shared historical event that shapes a cohort.
C	Adjacent category	Age-graded events are tied to age regardless of era, such as retirement at 65.
D	Confusion set	Non-normative events are unusual and individual, not cohort-wide.

12. Answer A Concept 8 • transfer

Which example is a non-normative influence on development?

Target word: identify non-normative — reverse direction **Decides:** An unusual, individual event.

A	Correct	An unpredictable event that happens to few people.
B	Adjacent category	Normative age-graded, tied to social timing.
C	Confusion set	Normative history-graded.
D	Inverted operation	Normative age-graded.

Triage grid

Write each item number in the box it belongs to.

	Right	Wrong
Sure	Owned.	Concept inversion — top priority. A wrong mental model; it survives rewording.
Unsure / guess	Recognition, not mastery. Re-drill with the transfer.	Not learned yet.

Trap tally

For every miss, find the letter you chose in the key and tally its trap. The biggest number is the pattern to drill.

Trap	What it does	In this drill	Your misses
Dropped element	Leaves out a required term or step.	1	
Wrong stem number	A figure copied from the prompt that is not the answer.	1	
Adjacent category	The right idea in the wrong bucket.	7	
Inverted operation	Direction flipped: add/subtract, cause/effect, higher/lower.	10	
Absolute language	Always, never, guarantee — where judgment applies.	6	
Confusion set	Every option is real; the test is exact role-matching.	10	
Camouflage	Answers a stem fact that was never the question.	1	

Anchor rows — the concept list

One row per concept: the rule to lock in, the trap that catches people, and the tell in the question that signals it.

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
1	Psychosocial tasks of adulthood	In the psychosocial stage model, young adults work on intimacy vs. isolation, middle adults on generativity vs. stagnation (contributing to the next generation), and older adults on integrity vs. despair (accepting one's life as meaningful).	Placing generativity in late life or integrity in midlife.	Mentoring and legacy vs. close partnership vs. life review.
2	Fluid vs. crystallized intelligence	Fluid intelligence (speed, novel problem solving) tends to decline from early adulthood; crystallized intelligence (knowledge, vocabulary, expertise) stays stable or grows into late adulthood.	Assuming all intelligence declines with age.	A new puzzle under time pressure vs. drawing on accumulated knowledge.
3	Socioemotional selectivity theory	As people perceive their remaining time as limited, they prioritize emotionally meaningful goals and prune social networks to close relationships.	Reading smaller networks in older adults as loneliness or withdrawal.	An older adult choosing fewer, closer relationships.
4	Selective optimization with compensation (SOC)	Successful aging involves selecting fewer, high-priority goals, optimizing effort toward them, and compensating for losses with new strategies or aids.	Viewing compensation (aids, strategies) as a sign of failure.	An older adult narrowing activities and using workarounds to keep doing what matters.
5	Emerging adulthood	Emerging adulthood (roughly 18–25) is marked by identity exploration, instability, self-focus, feeling in-between, and a sense of possibilities, and is most visible in industrialized societies.	Treating it as a universal biological stage or as delayed maturity.	A young adult changing jobs, majors, and relationships while exploring who they are.
6	Cross-sectional vs. longitudinal designs	Cross-sectional studies compare age groups at one time and risk confusing age with cohort effects; longitudinal studies follow the same people over time and risk attrition and practice effects; sequential designs combine both.	Reading a cross-sectional age difference as change within individuals.	"Different age groups tested in the same year" vs. "the same people tested every five years."

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
7	Activity, disengagement, and continuity theories	Activity theory says staying active supports well-being; disengagement theory says mutual withdrawal is natural; continuity theory says people adapt best by maintaining their long-standing patterns and roles.	Mixing up activity theory (more roles) with continuity theory (keeping familiar patterns).	A retiree who keeps doing a lifelong interest in a new form.
8	Life-course influences	Normative age-graded influences are tied to age (puberty, retirement age); normative history-graded influences affect a whole generation (a pandemic, a recession); non-normative influences are unusual personal events (winning a lottery, an early loss of a parent).	Classifying a widely shared historical event as non-normative.	Does the event hit most people at an age, a whole cohort at once, or only some individuals?

Course scope (public description): Adult Psychology provides an in-depth study of adult development. The learner will explore and apply major theories of adult development. The learner will analyze how individual characteristics and experiences, sociocultural factors, and structural contexts contribute to adult development. Focus on current evidence-based science is included, along with emphasis on observation, recognition, and application to individuals. There are no prerequisites for this course.